This by itself is hardly new in India. Among the thirty-two schemes that the Congress accused the Modi government of renaming/repackaging, three were previously named after Rajiv Gandhi, two after Indira Gandhi and one after Nehru. The BJP chose to name three after Deendayal Upadhyaya, one after Atal Bihari Vajpayee and nine carried the generic prefix 'Pradhan Mantri'. Schemes have been named after leaders of the ruling political party for decades. In itself, this is not surprising. In UP, as chief minister between 2012 and 2017, Akhilesh Yadav provided 15 lakh free laptops to college students as part of a government scheme, each carrying photos of him and his father Mulayam Singh Yadav.[18] His government also bought 1.8 crore school bags for children with his photo and the party symbol embossed on them. Ironically, many of these school bags with the SP symbol were later distributed by the Yogi government.[19] Tamil Nadu, too—which once distributed free TV sets to the poor under Karunanidhi's DMK regime, and mixers, grinders and fans under Jayalalithaa's AIADMK government—has long had such welfare schemes branded with the personality of individual chief ministers.

The BJP's Labharthee Model in UP: Sammelans and DBT Welfare Lists

The big question to ask is whether such schemes make a difference and whether people vote for them. Also, what did the BJP do that was different from normal political practice? The first difference is the transformative power of DBTs, the change in local power equations they heralded, and the massive scale-up of these schemes. That the entire bureaucratic and technology backend had been tested and was ready to be plugged into play by the time Modi came to power was the BJP's good fortune. The party capitalised on it by doubling down on it politically and scaling it up in a big way. The cash transfers created a new class of labharthees who could be politically harnessed. They played a vital role in the expansion of support among non-traditional BJP voters in rural areas. As a senior official in the UP chief minister's office (CMO) told me in Lucknow's Lok Bhawan, 'Direct transfers played a big part. If someone gets even Rs